14. Participation & Voting

Breakout Sessions

POLS 1101

8:40am-9:35am Baldwin 322

& 9:55am-10:50am Journalism 509

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Political Participation

- Elections don't guarantee democracy -> We need **regular, competitive elections**
- Beyond elections, people need channels to influence politics.
  - **Conventional participation**
  - **Unconventional participation** (political "resistance" / contentious politics)

  - **Is there clear distinction between "conventional" and "unconventional" participation? What matters more for your judgment, the intent** (to change policy vs. to overthrow authority) or **the approach** (legal vs. illegal)?
    - Teachers' strike for higher salaries
    - Online petition against a new surveillance law
    - Civil rights march with government permit
    - Farmers block highways to protest low crop prices
    - A student organization hosts a campus debate on voting reform
    - Environmental NGO sues the government for failing to meet emission targets
    - Voters boycott an election to protest corruption

Unconventional Participation

- **Key feature: (the intent is) against the established order/norms/institutions**
- **Some other characteristics**
  - Collective action involving "new" agents (e.g. the Selma Marches)

  -> **Direct action**: unconventional participation that involves **assembling crowds** to confront businesses and local governments to demand a hearing

  - Unconventional / "illegal" approaches (contextualized definitions)
  - Depending on some political opportunity structures
  - Always having emotional and symbolic slogans / claims

  -> People using unconventional behavior often have a strong **group consciousness**

  - Can lead to social change, or damage (depending on **state capacity** and **government responsiveness**)
- **When, if ever, is violent political participation justified?**
  - Freedom, Order, and Equality

Conventional Participation

- The objective of democratic institutions is **to make political participation conventional.**

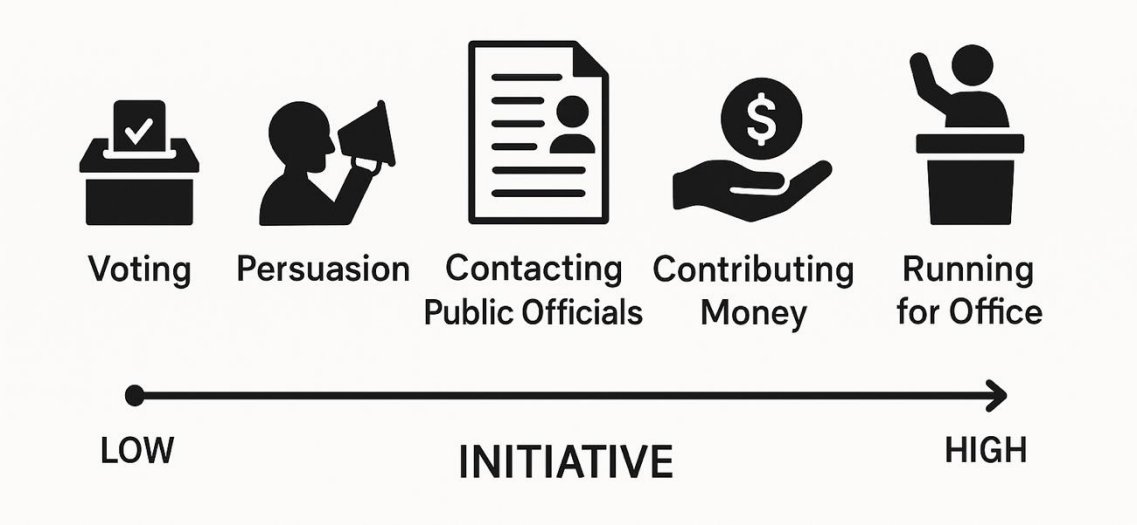
- Why conventional participation (for citizens)?
  - **For particular benefits** (supported by rationalism and pluralism):
    ask for services from the local government;
    hope to gain more from elected officials that they support or even contribute money to
  - **For broad policy objectives** (not directly related to individuals)

Conventional Participation

Share some of your experiences of "conventional participation"!

- How?
  - Often related to elections, but not restricted in elections!

Public Service Motivation



Resources

  - Legislative process: **congressional hearing**
  - Judicial process: **class action suit** (a legal action brought by a person or group on behalf of a number of people in similar circumstances)

Group Reading: Did shark attacks eat into Woodrow Wilson's votes in 1916?

- What is the main puzzle of the 1916 shark attack case?
- What is the key idea of ***Achen and Bartels***? What about ***Fowler and Hall***?
- What is their core disagreement?
- Which explanation do you find more convincing, and why?
- What does this article tell us about the limits of "rational voter" models?
- Can you think of a modern example similar to the shark attack case? (Hint: citizens' collective bounded rationality; not limited to electoral contexts)

Explaining Political Participation

- **The standard socio-economic explanation**
  - **More education**, higher income, white-collar occupations are related to more awareness, higher capability, and more resources to **more (conventional) participation**.
  - For unconventional participation, those who protest against US government policies tend to be more educated.
    - **Is it a universal conclusion across the world? China's case (incentive structure)**

- **The exit of elites (Sellars, 2019) "Emigration and Collective Action"**
  - https://isps.yale.edu/news/blog/2025/02/migration-forces-and-political-centralization-insights-from-emily-sellars
  - Who has "exit options" (not forced to leave), and why?
    What does this imply for the SES model of participation?
  - How does exit affect the people who cannot leave?
  - How does the central government respond to waves of exit?
    Why is it more responsive to collective action than exit threats?

Explaining Political Participation (cont`d)

- **Low voter turnout in America: Explanations**
  - Low willingness of young people to vote (accounting for low turnout right after the ratification of the 26th Amendment) – **pay attention to definitions!**
  - Attitudinal changes toward the government (low responsiveness)
  - High **learning costs, compliance costs, psychological costs** in **registration** / voting -> ***automatic registration; same day registration***
  - Lack of "punishment" for not voting -> ***compulsory voting***
  - Lack of political actors that mobilize the vote of particular social groups (its effect also depends on **types of citizens**, the **nature of the election**, and even **random factors – e.g. weather!**)

Next week…

- Read materials on **Campaigns & Elections** before class, and that will be helpful to participate in peer discussions.
- Feel free to email me if you have any questions!
- ENJOY YOUR WEEKEND!